Chapter 1: Dreams Crushed

Dor knew he was going to hear bad news when his master called him into the study at dawn. Normally Dor didn't even say good morning to the master until he had scrubbed the cauldron, fetched water, milked the spiders, and let the miniature unicorn – or minicorn, as Dor liked to call her – out into the garden. If the master wanted to speak to him, it had to be important. And given his recent failures, Dor couldn't imagine it would be good.

He slipped on his wide robe, that made him look skinny and knocked on the door before entering the study. "Come in," the master whispered seriously. That was odd; he usually shouted for Dor to come in.

Dor slipped into the study. His master, Apollinarius, was indeed looking irritated. He was sitting at his desk holding a letter and his quill. "Sit," he ordered quietly. Dor obeyed. The master fidgeted with his beard uncomfortably. "Young man," he stated quickly, "you are never going to be a wizard."

Dor tried to explain, but the master cut him off. "No no, there is no more debating it. I have irrefutable proof." He pulled a tiny bottle from the folds of his ample robe. "I made this potion specifically to test your maximum magical potential. It seemed better than inviting a troll witch over to devour your soul and tell me if she tasted any trace of magic in you." He chuckled like he had made a joke. Dor didn't really find it funny, and he was pretty sure troll witches couldn't actually suck souls, but he held his tongue.

Appolinarius coughed uncomfortably and continued. “All humans have at least some magic in them, though very few have any potential to become great wizards. At least I thought all humans had some magic, until now.”

He tossed the vial to Dor, who examined the bottle. It was full of royal blue liquid, but Dor wasn’t sure what that meant. His master explained, “That potion is very sensitive to magic. Even the most ordinary human will turn the potion purple. A talented individual will turn the potion magenta; and a great magician will turn it red. There are other colors the potion will turn for other magics: green for druidry and fey magic, brown for troll magic. But you – well, your dog has more potential for magic than you do.”

Dor stared at the bottle in disbelief. He knew he had never been able to perform even the simplest of spells, but humans always took longer than other races to learn magic. Dor had always figured his magic would eventually show up. How could Dor have no magic at all? Magic was inherited by blood, and Dor had more magical blood than any human he knew. His father was a wizard. His grandfather was a wizard. His brother was already mastering advanced spells back at home, and he was only twelve. His mother was a druidess, and his grandmother had been a powerful fairy. How could he not have magic?

“It is most perplexing,” Apollinarius stated thoughtfully, mirroring Dor’s thoughts for once. “Given your parents, you ought to be even more talented than me, or at least mediocre. Unless you were switched at birth, or just a magical defect. Why you are not magical is a mystery, but the fact that you have no magic is simply undeniable. You have only wasted

your time as my apprentice, and I have wasted my time trying to teach you. It's a shame really – you certainly worked harder than any apprentice I have ever had. But you can't just work for magic – you must be born with magic. That is why I have called you here, to release you from your apprenticeship with me. Go home. My letter to your family will reach your parents before you do, so they will be expecting you." He waved his hand at the scroll in his hand, and a raven picked it up and carried it away.

"Sir," Dor wondered sadly, "What am I supposed to do if I can't do magic?"

"Do something else," Apollinarus stated unhelpfully. "You're still what, twelve?"

"Fifteen," Dor corrected.

"Oh dear," Apollinarius cringed. "Well then, find something else to do quickly. It takes at least seven to fourteen years to learn anything worth learning. If it's any consolation, you have some minor magic resistance that will make you a little harder to curse than most humans. Casting spells on you will take more magic and energy than it would to cast it on an ordinary person. Not that it will slow a good wizard down much."

Dor nodded a polite acknowledgment, but he wasn't very comforted. His former master shifted uncomfortably. "Well now, I need to brew a spell, or cast a potion… I need to be left alone. You will need to pack your belongings and be out by dawn tomorrow. Good luck."

Dor went to his room and began to pack. There was nothing about the dingy room itself he would miss. But it had

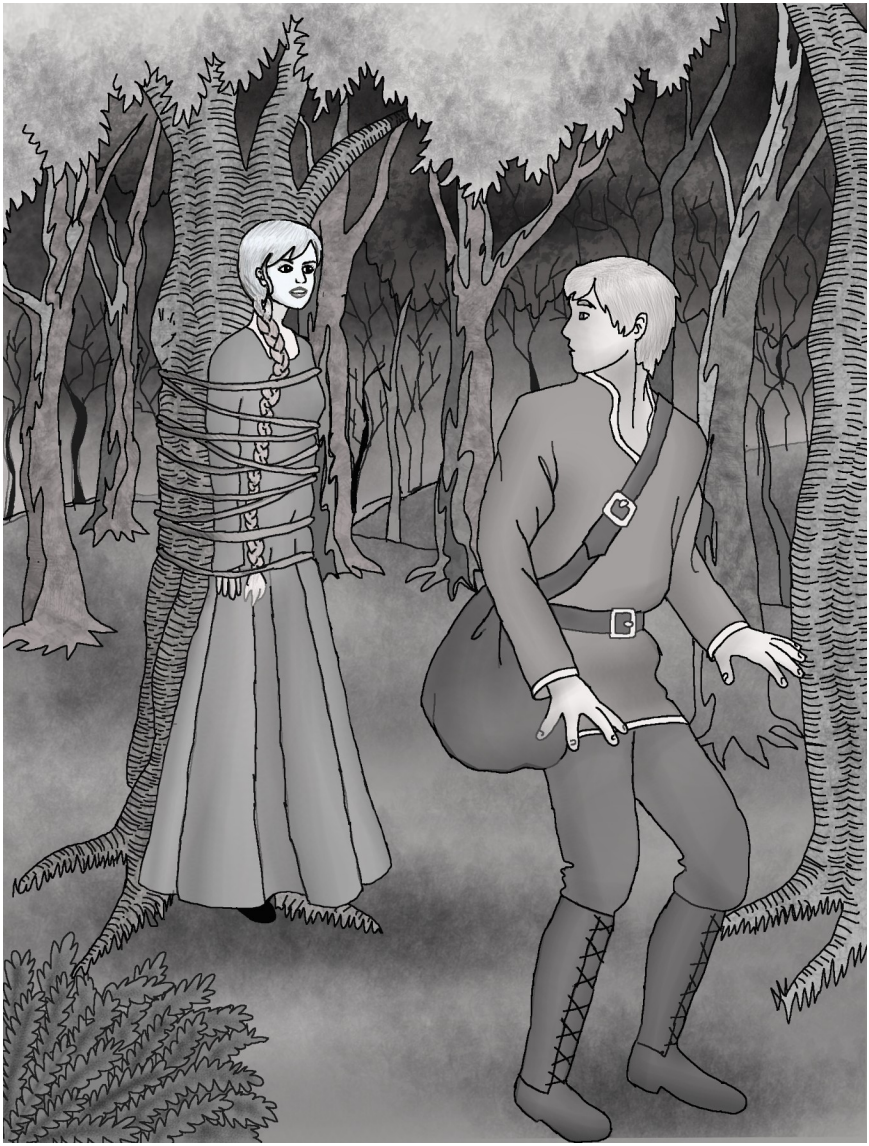
been his sanctuary for seven years. Working for Appolinarius had not been the most pleasant of apprenticeships, and having a retreat had made the years more bearable. Dor looked through his clothes, but they were all wizard apprentice robes. No need to keep those anymore. He decided to leave them for Appolinarius' next apprentice.

Dor didn't see any point in taking his straw-mat or bedding either. He was pretty sure the dungeons of Elantain back home had nicer beds. Dor had not come to study with Appolinarius because his life was good there. He had left his happy life in Elantain because Appolinarius was supposed to be the best at turning talentless novices into wizards. Hard work and dedication was supposed to pay off – but it hadn't.

Dor wasn't going to wait until dawn the next day to leave. He grabbed one change of clothes, what coins he had, and the letters he had exchanged with his family, mostly his mother. He knew his mother would try to encourage him by saying she would be proud of him, no matter what he did with his life. Still, Dor didn't know anything other than magic. And even if he found something else to do with his life, he was forever going to be the misfit in his family.

Then he shoved those belongings in a satchel and headed toward home. He realized somewhere nearly a mile from Appolinarius' tower that he hadn't had breakfast, but he didn't care. He wasn't hungry.

Home was near the center of the kingdom of Elantain, about two day's journey away – a day and a half if he cut through the troll woods. With the day still young, and the sun just up, it should be perfectly safe to take that route. Dor would rather get home sooner.



He hurried through the troll woods, wondering what he was going to do. He was too old to start most apprenticeships. No master would take him on, unless perhaps he was remarkably talented. Dor didn't think that likely.

Dor stared at the path without bothering to look around, so he was surprised when a young woman's voice called from only feet away. "Good morning, young man," she greeted. Dor jumped and wheeled around.

The voice had come from a young woman who looked to be about his age. After years of Appolinarius's scowls – which seemed to spread even to the occasional visitor – a young, pleasant looking girl with a sweet smile was a welcomed sight. She was smiling so calmly, he almost didn't notice at first that she was tied to a large oak tree. "A very sunny morning, isn't it?" she commented casually. "You weren't in a hurry, were you?"

"No," Dor replied. "Are you all right, miss? What happened? Do you need help?"

"Well, I certainly wouldn't refuse some help," the young woman replied. "Just be careful with the rope – it's an enchanted rope. It might try to entangle you too. But I do believe I know the incantation to untie it, only it won't work if someone tied up says it. Do you think you could try saying the incantation?"

"I could try," Dor offered. He was pretty good with speaking incantations. Having them succeed was another story. "What should I say?"

"Wunraflen," the young woman prompted.

“Wunraflen,” Dor repeated. Nothing happened. He tried it a few more times, but it did no good.

“Perhaps I misheard it,” the young woman noted with a disappointed tone. “Thank you for trying though. I’m Wren. What’s your name?”

“Dor,” he replied, looking carefully at the rope. It looked a bit strained, and worse for the wear. Enchanted ropes held onto their victims, no matter what. The ropes could grow and shrink and shift to keep hold of them, and the ropes couldn’t be cut by any ordinary methods. But they still had their limits, and this one looked like it had been pushed near its limit. “How did you get tied up in this rope in the first place?”

“Trolls,” Wren explained. “I met them last night, and they wanted to eat me, but I was – well, not very tasty. So they decided to wait until the – untastiness wore off.”

Dor looked oddly at her. “Untastiness? I thought trolls liked everything.”

“Not quite everything,” Wren countered. “Apparently they don’t like certain birds, and I smelled like a bird last night.”

“I’ll have to keep that in mind if I ever encounter a troll,” Dor noted. “What were you doing in the troll forest after dark?”

“I got lost,” Wren answered simply.

“Well,” Dor offered, “perhaps I can help you get unlost.”

“Unlost?”

Dor was too busy staring at the rope to comment. The obvious strain on the rope gave him an idea. He took a piece

of the rope and looped it around his wrist. “What are you doing?” Wren demanded with some alarm. The rope snaked its way around Dor, entangling him. But it couldn’t hold Dor, Wren, and the tree. It would have to let go of something – it let go of the tree.

That left Dor and Wren tied together. “Well, I knew the rope would drop something – I was hoping it would release you,” Dor admitted. He suspected if Wren said ‘wunraflen’ after she was freed, the rope would let him go.

“But now we can walk,” Wren pointed out. She seemed to have gotten over her initial shock. “Perhaps we can get help somewhere. I wish I had heard that incantation right, but I suppose it won’t help much now that we’re both tied up.”

“No,” Dor noted. “The incantation you mentioned sounded right. The problem is me. I have no magic.” It hadn’t been the first time he had failed to properly use a magical rope.

Wren shook her head . “I don’t think the troll who caught me had magic either. You don’t have to have magic to use magical items.”

“I think you have to have a little magic,” Dor explained. He remembered what Apollinarius had said, that a dog probably had more magic than him. “How about we go towards my home in Elantain? If we meet someone on our way, we can try the incantation again. If not, then my father will know what to do. He’s a wizard.”

Wren agreed. “That sounds like a better plan than being eaten by trolls,” she smiled. “Lead the way.”

It was a little awkward, and more slow, than walking normally, but Dor and Wren walked together towards Dor's home. Wren talked with him to pass the time away. "So Dor, what business brings you to the troll woods?"

"Going home," Dor explained. "My master – my former master sent me home."

Wren looked surprised. "On what grounds?"

"I have no magic," Dor replied, "not even a little."

"But how would he know that?" Wren wondered.

Dor told her about Apollinarius' potion that could test his magic. Wren seemed intrigued by the idea. "And he said you would be hard to curse?"

Dor nodded. "But he also said it wouldn't slow down a good wizard much." He chuckled. "Besides, how likely am I to run into an evil wizard or someone who wants to curse me?"

Wren frowned slightly. "You might," she stated. "You never know. Curses can happen to anyone." Her smile returned. "So, what are you going to do now?"

"I don't know," Dor admitted. "I've honestly never imagined being anything but a wizard. I always thought my magic was just buried deeply, and if I tried hard enough, it would awaken. Magic has been in my family for five generations. I have a name to live up to."

"What name is that?" Wren asked.

"Have you heard of the wizard Maximillian?" Dor asked.

Wren's eyes widened. "You mean Theodoricus Maximillian the fourth? Defeater of the dark wizard, Gorgorath?"

“That’s my father,” Dor confirmed. “And soon he’s going to find out Theodoricus Maximillian the fifth can’t carry on his

Wren didn’t seem to have an answer to that, so they walked in silence for a few miles.